PART I · PITCH · 1

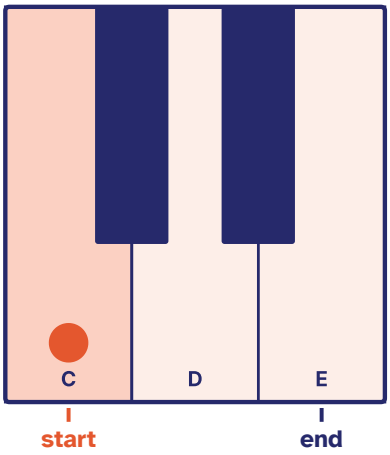
The keyboard

Left is **low**, right is **high**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**. Each group has a first white key, just to its left: **C** for the two, **F** for the three. Find the group, find its first key, then walk on.

THE SECRET

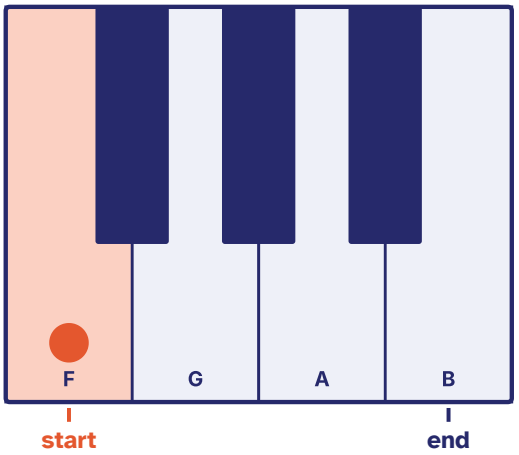
Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: C starts the two, F starts the three · E and B end them

THE RULE

Find the group, then its first key. Looking for D or E? Find two black keys and start on C. Looking for G, A or B? Find three black keys and start on F. You never have to count from far away.

Seven letters, two families

The white keys use seven letters, **A B C D E F G**, then start again, like the days of the week. There is no H: after G comes A again. They live in two families: **C D E** round the two black keys, **F G A B** round the three.

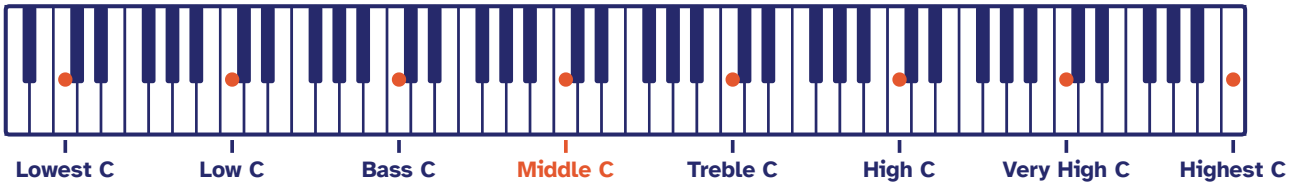


The eight Cs have names

The C nearest the middle is **Middle C**. The Cs either side are **Bass C** and **Treble C**; further out, **Low C** and **High C**. At the ends: **Lowest C** at the bottom, and **Very High C** and **Highest C**, the very last key, at the top. From one C to the next is an **octave**: C D E F G A B C, eight notes, both Cs included.

Theory books and apps number the Cs instead: C1 to C8, with Middle C as C4.

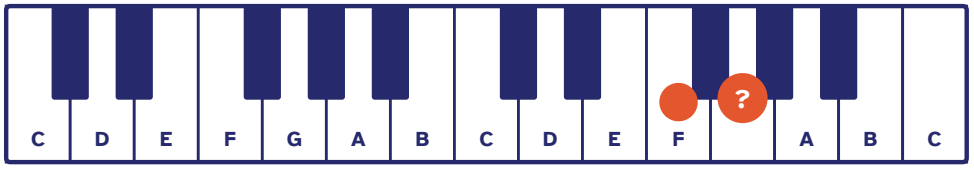
PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED



All 88 keys, eight Cs: the five in the middle are the ones you will use most

EXAMPLE 1

Find G

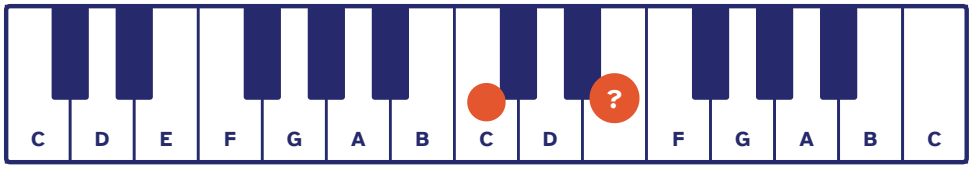


1. **Which family?** G is in F G A B: look for **three** black keys.
2. **Find its first key:** F, just left of the three (the red dot).
3. **Walk on one key.** That is the **?**.

The **?** is **G**: the key after F. No need to start from C and count five.

EXAMPLE 2

Find E



1. **Which family?** E is in C D E: look for **two** black keys.
2. **Find its first key:** C, just left of the two (the red dot).
3. **Walk on:** C, D ... the third key is the **?**.

The **?** is **E**: the last of the C D E family, just right of the two black keys.

EXAMPLE 3

Find B



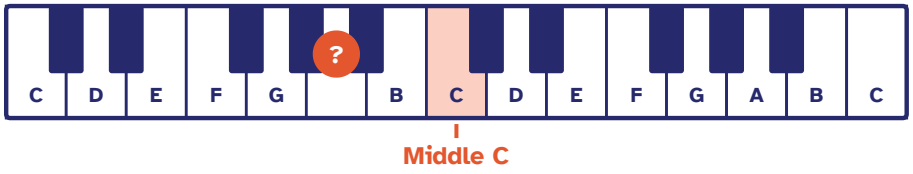
1. **Which family?** B is in F G A B: three black keys.
2. **Start on F** (the red dot).
3. **Walk on:** F, G, A ... the last key of the family is the **?**.

The **?** is **B**: the last of F G A B, just right of the three black keys.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find the A below Middle C

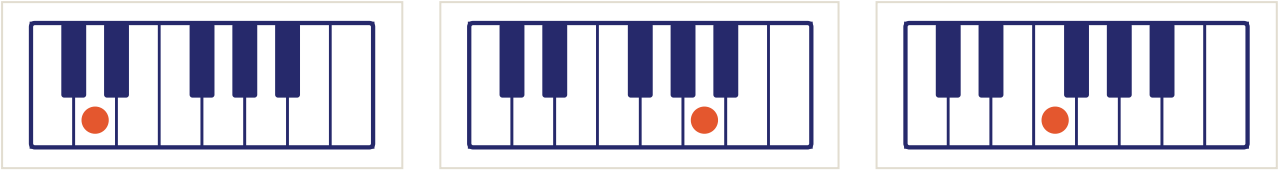


1. **Which family?** A is in F G A B.
2. **From Middle C, look left** for the nearest three black keys, and start on their F.
3. **Walk on:** F, G … the third key is the **?**.

The **?** is **A**: F, G, A. Find the family first, and every key is at most three steps away.

GAME

Name the key



1 2 3

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Name each red key.

Answer: 1 D (C, then D) · 2 A (F, G, A) · 3 F (the first of the three).

GAME

Which family?

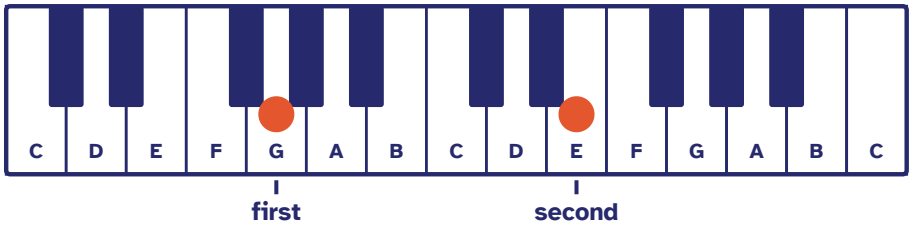
1	2	3	4	5	6
D	A	F	E	B	G

Does each white key live with the **two** black keys (start on C) or the **three** (start on F)?

Answer: 1 two · 2 three · 3 three (the first) · 4 two (the last) · 5 three (the last) · 6 three.

EXAMPLE 6

Higher or lower?



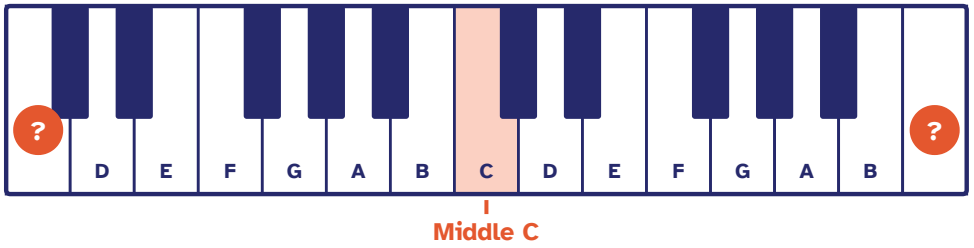
1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 5

Find Bass C and Treble C



1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Walk left** to the next pair of black keys. The C just left of it is one **?**.
3. **Walk right** the same way, to the next pair: the other **?**.

Left **?**: **Bass C**. Right **?**: **Treble C**. Each is one octave, eight notes, from Middle C.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

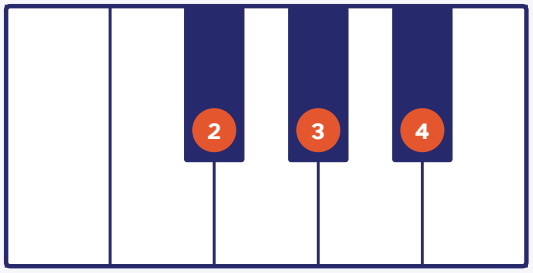


Play every C, then every F.

Bottom to top, saying the names: Lowest C, Low C, Bass C, Middle C, Treble C, High C, Very High C, Highest C. Then every F: left of the three.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Right hand, fingers **2 3 4** on the three black keys. Play from the top: **4 3 2**, 4 3 2, then 2 2 2 2, 3 3 3 3, 4 3 2. A whole tune, and not one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes and slide your hand along: two bumps, and the key to their left is C; three bumps, and the key to their left is F.

TRAP

- × Counting every key from C: find the nearest group and start from its C or F.
- × Mixing up the families: C is left of the **two** black keys, F left of the **three**.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 26 · The staff and the keyboard p. 32

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 1 · Online: Library › Keyboard